SAMPLE

The Valley of Tuwa: The Sacred Valley

The Valley of Tuwa (طوى) in the Quran

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Introduction

The Quran tells the story of a valley -- a valley that was so sacred that Allah commanded Musa to remove his sandals. The valley is called Tuwa, and it is the place where Allah spoke to Musa directly -- the place where the prophethood was given, the place where the mission was assigned, and the place where the human being stood in the presence of the divine.

The Quran says:

"Indeed, I am your Lord, so remove your sandals. Indeed, you are in the sacred valley of Tuwa" (20:12).

And:

"When his Lord called him in the sacred valley of Tuwa" (79:16).

Tuwa is the place of the calling -- the calling that changed the life of Musa from the shepherd to the prophet. Tuwa is the place of the sacredness -- the sacredness that required the removal of the sandals, the acknowledgment that the place where Allah speaks is the place that is set apart. Tuwa is the place of the mission -- the mission that was given in the valley and that was carried to the court of Pharaoh. Tuwa is the place of the dialogue -- the dialogue between the human and the divine, the conversation that is the model of the communication between Allah and His prophets.

This book -- the twelfth and final book in the Places in the Qur'an series -- covers the Valley of Tuwa: its name, the calling of Musa, the removal of the sandals, the fire and the voice, the mission to Pharaoh, the dialogue between Musa and Allah, its lessons, and its connections to the other sacred places. The book follows the same approach as the first eleven books -- Makkah: The Holy City, Madinah: The City of the Prophet, Al-Quds: The Night Journey, Egypt: The Land of Pharaoh, Mount Judi: The Resting Place, Iram: The Lost City, Madyan: The Land of Shu'ayb, Sodom: The Cities of Lut, Nineveh: The City of Yunus, The Cave: The Sleepers, and Babylon: The Source of Magic -- exploring the place as the Quran presents it.

The Places in the Qur'an series traces the sacred geography of the Quran. The eleven previous books explored the centers of worship, community, tradition, trial, survival, transience, commerce, immorality, repentance, preservation, and forbidden knowledge. This twelfth and final book explores the Valley of Tuwa -- the center of the divine calling. The twelve places are the twelve dimensions of the sacred geography: the House, the community, the tradition, the test, the survival, the transience, the commerce, the immorality, the repentance, the preservation, the forbidden knowledge, and the divine calling. The person who understands the twelve understands that the places where Allah acted are the places that teach -- and the valley where Allah spoke to Musa is the valley that teaches that the place where the divine calls is the place that is sacred, and the person who is called by the divine is the person who is transformed.

The Valley of Tuwa is the twelfth and final pillar of the sacred geography -- the pillar that teaches that the calling of Allah is the transformation, and the person who hears the voice of the Lord is the person who is changed forever, and the valley that was the place of the calling is the valley that is the final lesson -- the lesson that the series of the places ends where the prophethood began: in the sacred valley where Allah spoke.

Chapter 1: The Name -- The Valley of Tuwa in the Quran

The Valley of Tuwa is mentioned twice in the Quran -- in two surahs, in two contexts, but with one meaning. The first mention is in Surah Taha:

"Indeed, I am your Lord, so remove your sandals. Indeed, you are in the sacred valley of Tuwa" (20:12).

The second mention is in Surah An-Nazi'at:

"When his Lord called him in the sacred valley of Tuwa" (79:16).

The two mentions are the significance: the valley that is mentioned twice is the valley whose story is told twice -- and the story that is told twice is the story that is emphasized. The two mentions are the lesson: the Quran mentions the valley of Tuwa in two places to show the importance of the place -- the place where the prophethood was given to Musa, the place where Allah spoke directly, and the place that is the beginning of the mission.

The name "Tuwa" (طوى) in the Quran is the name of the valley -- the valley that was the place of the calling. The name is the significance: the valley that is named is the valley that is known -- the known valley that was the place of the divine speech. The name is the lesson: the place that is named by Allah is the place that is honored by Allah -- and the honor that is the name is the honor that is the sacredness. The person who reads the name should know: the valley that is named by Allah is the valley that is remembered by Allah, and the remembering that is the name is the remembering that is the lesson.

The Quran describes the valley as "sacred" -- "the sacred valley of Tuwa" (20:12, 79:16). The sacredness is the significance: the valley that is called sacred is the valley that is set apart -- set apart by the presence of the divine, set apart by the speech of the Lord. The sacredness is the lesson: the place where Allah speaks is the place that is sacred -- and the sacredness that is the valley is the sacredness that requires the response. The person who is in the sacred valley should know: the place that is sacred is the place that demands the reverence, and the reverence that is the response is the reverence that is the removal of the sandals.

The Valley of Tuwa is near the mountain -- the mountain that is associated with the story of Musa. The valley and the mountain are the significance: the place where Musa was called is the place that includes the valley and the mountain -- the valley where the calling happened and the mountain where the revelation continued. The valley and the mountain are the lesson: the person who is called by Allah is the person who is called in the valley and who is given the revelation on the mountain -- and the two are the two places of the prophethood of Musa, the two places that are the sacred geography of the mission.

The Valley of Tuwa is the place of the first revelation to Musa -- the place where Allah spoke to Musa for the first time. The first revelation is the significance: the valley that was the place of the first revelation is the valley that was the beginning of the prophethood -- the prophethood that started in the valley and that continued for the lifetime. The first revelation is the lesson: the person who is given the first revelation is the person who is changed -- and the change that is the first revelation is the change that is the transformation from the shepherd to the prophet.

The Valley of Tuwa is unique among the sacred places -- it is the only place in the Quran that is explicitly called "sacred" (muqaddas) in connection with a direct command to remove the sandals. The uniqueness is the significance: the valley that is unique is the valley that is special -- the special place where the divine speech was given and the special place where the human being stood in the presence of the Lord. The uniqueness is the lesson: the person who studies the sacred geography should note the uniqueness of the valley -- and the uniqueness that is the valley is the uniqueness that teaches that the place where Allah speaks is the place that is unlike any other.

The word "Tuwa" (طوى) carries layers of meaning in the Arabic language. Some scholars connect it to the idea of folding -- the valley that was "folded" in the sacredness, the place that was set apart by being wrapped in the divine. Others connect it to the idea of the twice -- the valley that was blessed twice, mentioned twice, honored twice. The meaning is the significance: the name that carries the layers is the name that carries the depth -- and the depth that is the name is the depth that invites the reflection. The meaning is the lesson: the person who studies the name should study the layers -- and the layers that are the name are the layers that are the sacredness, and the sacredness that is the layers is the sacredness that is the valley.

The Valley of Tuwa holds a special place in the sacred geography of the Quran. It is the only place that is called "the sacred valley" -- the valley that was set apart by the direct speech of Allah. The other places in the series are sacred by association -- Makkah by the House, Madinah by the community, Jerusalem by the prophets. The Valley of Tuwa is sacred by the speech -- the speech that was given directly, the speech that was the calling, the speech that was the beginning of the prophethood. The special place is the lesson: the valley that is sacred by the speech is the valley that teaches that the sacredness that comes from the speech is the sacredness that is the highest -- and the highest that is the sacredness is the highest that is the valley.